



Captain in distress: Rohit Sharma's loss of form in the latter stages of IPL 2024 will be a concern for the Men in Blue. K. MURALIKUMAR



Lack of spark: In this IPL, Hardik made 216 at a strike rate of 143.0 and was dismissed 12 times in 13 innings. VIJAY SONEJI

INDIA'S T20 WORLD CUP SQUAD IS A FINE BALANCE OF EXPERIENCED PLAYERS AND EMERGING TALENTS, WHICH AIMS TO NAVIGATE THIS EVER-EVOLVING HYPER-SPECIALISED FORMAT.

shedding caution completely in a format where each over is five per cent of the game. That was until West Indies, in 2016, and then England, in 2022, persuaded the world that naked aggression was perhaps the future.

Those transformations worked because these teams had ample playing resources and a glut of attacking batsmen to pick from. But with the selection choices of this Indian team, one always gets the feeling that it needs to try really hard in ICC T20 tournaments to conquer the final frontier.

In T20 World Cups, India appears to have a strong preference for conventional batting depth over

specialised power-hitters. However, there was a complete about-turn in the time between the last T20 World Cup and this one, when it temporarily jettisoned that approach by including the likes of Rinku Singh, who played 15 T20Is, Tilak Verma (16), and Jitesh Sharma (9) in its playing XIs. Yet two of these three did not make the cut for the World Cup, while Rinku is in the reserves.

They say the IPL is long enough for you to play yourself in and out of form. India's captain and vice-captain can vouch for the latter.

Returning to action after five months due to an ankle injury that he suffered during the ODI World Cup last October, vice-captain Hardik

Pandya, India's likely fourth pace-bowling option, bowled his full quota of four overs only five times in IPL 2024. The Mumbai Indians captain often bowled with the new ball this year, ahead of Jasprit Bumrah, and conceded 10.25 runs per over in this phase while picking up only two wickets. With the bat, Hardik made 216 at a strike rate of 143.0 and was dismissed 12 times in 13 innings.

Meanwhile, India skipper Rohit Sharma began the season on a high, even hitting his second IPL century — his first since 2012 — in MI's loss against CSK, but his form tapered off as the season wore on. Rohit hit 89 in 76 balls in the PowerPlay with a